

Northwind Analytics Pvt. Ltd.

Employee Handbook — FY2026 Edition

This handbook is a test artifact created to exercise a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) knowledge-base server. It is written as a substantive, section-dense company policy document — including tables, sub-policies, and specific figures — so semantic search has meaningful, well-differentiated content to retrieve from, rather than short single-paragraph stubs.

Contents

1. Company Overview
2. Leave Policy
3. Compensation and Payroll Policy
4. Expense and Reimbursement Policy
5. Travel Policy
6. Remote and Hybrid Work Policy
7. Code of Conduct
8. IT and Data Security Policy
9. Employee Benefits
10. Learning and Development Policy
11. Onboarding Process
12. Performance Review and Promotion Policy
13. Health, Safety, and Workplace Policy
14. Grievance Redressal and Anti-Harassment Policy
15. Exit and Separation Policy
16. Employee Referral Bonus Policy
17. Data Retention and Privacy Policy
18. Frequently Asked Questions

1. Company Overview

Northwind Analytics Pvt. Ltd. was founded in 2016 and operates as a data and AI consulting firm serving clients across the retail, healthcare, and financial services sectors. The company employs approximately 480 people across three office locations: Bengaluru (headquarters), Pune, and a satellite office in Hyderabad, in addition to a fully distributed team of roughly 60 remote employees.

The company is organized into four practice groups: Data Engineering, Applied AI, Analytics Consulting, and Platform Engineering, each led by a Practice Director who reports to the VP of Delivery. Corporate functions — HR, Finance, Legal, and IT — report to the COO.

Core Values

- **Client-first delivery** — decisions are evaluated first by their impact on client outcomes.
- **Radical transparency** — problems are surfaced early, not hidden until a review cycle.
- **Ownership over instructions** — employees are expected to identify and fix problems proactively rather than waiting to be told.
- **Sustainable pace** — the company explicitly discourages routine overtime as a substitute for proper planning.

2. Leave Policy

Northwind Analytics provides several distinct categories of leave, summarized in the table below and described in further detail afterward.

Leave Type	Annual Entitlement	Eligibility	Carry Forward
Annual (Earned) Leave	24 days/year	From day 1 (usable after 90 days)	Up to 10 days
Sick Leave	12 days/year	From day 1	Not carried forward
Casual Leave	6 days/year	From day 1	Not carried forward
Parental Leave (Primary)	26 weeks	After 6 months of service	N/A
Parental Leave (Secondary)	2 weeks	After 6 months of service	N/A
Bereavement Leave	5 days/event	From day 1	N/A
Sabbatical Leave	Up to 90 days, unpaid	After 3 years of service	N/A

Annual leave accrues at a rate of 2 days per completed month of service and becomes usable once an employee has completed 90 days of employment, though it begins accruing immediately from the date of joining. Any unused annual leave beyond the 10-day carry-forward cap is forfeited on December 31st of each year unless local labor law requires otherwise.

Sick leave does not require advance approval but must be reported to a manager before 10:00 AM on the day of absence via the HR portal. Sick leave exceeding 3 consecutive days requires a medical certificate to be uploaded within 5 working days of returning to work.

Casual leave is intended for short, planned personal matters and cannot be combined with public holidays to extend a break beyond 4 consecutive calendar days without additional approval from a Practice Director.

Parental leave notification must be provided to HR at least 30 days before the expected start date. Employees returning from parental leave are guaranteed reinstatement to their original role or an equivalent role at the same level and compensation.

Sabbatical leave requests must be submitted at least 60 days in advance and require approval from both the employee's manager and the relevant Practice Director. Role and level upon return are not guaranteed to be identical but will be at an equivalent compensation band.

3. Compensation and Payroll Policy

Salaries are processed and disbursed on the last working day of each month via direct bank transfer. Payslips are made available through the HR portal by the 1st working day of the following month.

Compensation Bands

Level	Title Examples	Annual Bonus Target	Review Cycle
L1–L2	Associate, Analyst	8% of base	Annual
L3–L4	Senior Analyst, Consultant	12% of base	Annual
L5–L6	Lead Consultant, Manager	18% of base	Annual
L7+	Principal, Director	25% of base + equity	Annual + mid-year check-in

Annual bonus payouts are tied to both individual performance rating and overall company performance against revenue targets, and are paid out in the April payroll cycle following the October performance review. A minimum individual rating of 3 out of 5 is required to receive any bonus payout.

Salary revisions are considered once per year, effective from the April payroll cycle, based on the October performance review outcome. Off-cycle salary revisions are only granted in cases of promotion, internal role change with significant scope increase, or approved retention counter-offers.

Any changes to bank account details must be updated in the HR portal at least 10 working days before the next payroll run to guarantee timely processing; changes submitted later may result in payment to the previous account on file.

4. Expense and Reimbursement Policy

Employees may claim reimbursement for legitimate business expenses including client travel, client meals, software subscriptions required for work, and approved training courses. All claims must be submitted through the Expense Portal within 30 days of the expense being incurred, accompanied by an itemized receipt.

Expense Category Caps

Category	Metro Cities	Non-Metro Cities	Approval Needed Above
Hotel (per night)	■6,000	■4,000	■8,000
Client meals (per person)	■2,500	■2,000	■4,000
Personal meal per-diem (travel)	■1,200	■1,000	N/A
Local conveyance (per day)	■800	■600	■1,500
Office supplies (per month)	■1,000	■1,000	■2,500

Alcohol is reimbursable only when entertaining external clients, and only up to 50% of the total bill amount. Expense claims exceeding ■25,000 in a single submission require secondary approval from Finance in addition to the manager's approval. Claims submitted more than 90 days after the expense date will not be reimbursed except in documented exceptional circumstances approved by a Practice Director.

Reimbursements are processed within 7 working days of approval and are paid out along with the next payroll cycle or via a separate bank transfer for urgent cases exceeding ■15,000.

5. Travel Policy

All domestic travel must be booked through the approved corporate travel portal at least 5 working days in advance where possible. International travel requires written pre-approval from a Director-level approver at least 2 weeks in advance, along with a business justification submitted through the Travel Portal.

Booking Class by Level

Level	Domestic Flights	International Flights	Hotel Category
L1–L4	Economy	Economy (Premium Economy if >6hrs)	3-star or equivalent
L5–L6	Economy	Premium Economy	4-star or equivalent
L7+	Economy (Business if >4hrs)	Business (if >6hrs)	4-star or equivalent

Employees travelling for client engagements longer than 4 consecutive weeks are eligible for a weekly home-visit flight, subject to manager approval, capped at one round trip every 3 weeks. A travel insurance policy is automatically applied to all company-booked travel at no cost to the employee.

Visa costs, vaccination costs required for travel, and airport lounge access for flights longer than 6 hours are reimbursable for L5 and above. Rental car usage requires prior approval and is only reimbursable where public transport or company-arranged transport is not a reasonable alternative.

6. Remote and Hybrid Work Policy

Northwind Analytics operates a hybrid work model. Employees are expected to work from the office a minimum of 3 days per week, with Tuesday and Thursday designated as mandatory in-office collaboration days for all teams, unless a client engagement requires a different on-site schedule.

Fully remote work arrangements may be approved on a case-by-case basis for roles that do not require regular in-person collaboration, subject to written approval from both the employee's manager and the People Operations team. Fully remote employees must maintain a stable internet connection of at least 50 Mbps and be available during core hours of 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM in their registered time zone.

Employees working remotely for more than 2 consecutive weeks from a location outside their registered city (a 'workation') must inform HR at least 5 business days in advance. Workations outside the employee's home country require additional Legal and Tax review due to potential compliance implications, and must be approved at least 30 days in advance.

The company provides a one-time home office setup allowance of ■15,000 for employees on an approved fully-remote arrangement, covering items such as a monitor, chair, or desk, claimable within the first 60 days of the arrangement being approved.

7. Code of Conduct

All employees are expected to act with integrity, honesty, and respect in every interaction with colleagues, clients, and partners. Harassment, discrimination, or retaliation of any kind will not be tolerated and should be reported immediately to HR or through the confidential ethics hotline at ethics@northwindanalytics.example.

Conflicts of interest — including outside employment, financial interests in vendors or competitors, or close personal relationships with direct reports — must be disclosed to HR in writing within 15 days of the conflict arising. Undisclosed conflicts discovered later are treated as a Code of Conduct violation regardless of intent.

Confidential company and client information must not be shared outside the organization, including on personal social media accounts, without explicit written authorization from the Legal team. This obligation survives termination of employment and applies for a minimum of 3 years after an employee's last working day.

Gifts from clients or vendors valued above \$5,000 must be declared to HR and, where practical, declined or redirected to a company-wide raffle rather than kept personally.

Violations of the Code of Conduct are handled through a progressive disciplinary process: verbal warning, written warning, final written warning, and termination — except in cases of gross misconduct (including harassment, fraud, or data theft), which may result in immediate termination without progressing through earlier stages.

8. IT and Data Security Policy

All company laptops must have disk encryption and endpoint protection software enabled at all times. Employees must not disable these tools under any circumstances; doing so triggers an automated alert to the Security team and a mandatory re-training session.

Passwords for company systems must be at least 14 characters long, rotated every 90 days, and must not be reused across the last 10 passwords. Multi-factor authentication is mandatory for all systems handling client data, and single-factor access is disabled entirely for any system classified as Tier 1 (client PII or financial data).

Client data must never be downloaded to personal devices or personal cloud storage accounts (e.g. personal Google Drive or Dropbox). All client data processing must occur within company-approved, audited environments only, and any exception requires written sign-off from both the Security team and the client's designated data owner.

Any suspected security incident — including a lost device, phishing attempt, or unauthorized access — must be reported to security@northwindanalytics.example within 1 hour of discovery. Delayed reporting beyond 24 hours may result in disciplinary action independent of the severity of the underlying incident.

USB storage devices are disabled by default on all company laptops. Exceptions require a documented business justification and expire automatically after 30 days unless renewed.

9. Employee Benefits

Health Insurance Coverage

Plan Tier	Coverage (Sum Insured)	Covers	Waiting Period
Base (all employees)	■5,00,000/family/year	Employee, spouse, 2 children	None
Enhanced (L5+)	■10,00,000/family/year	Employee, spouse, 2 children, parents	None
Critical Illness Rider	■15,00,000 additional	Employee only	90 days

Employees are enrolled in the company provident fund at a contribution rate of 12% of basic salary, matched equally by the company. Voluntary additional contributions up to 20% of basic salary are permitted through the Voluntary Provident Fund scheme.

An annual wellness reimbursement of up to ■10,000 covers gym memberships, fitness classes, or mental health counseling sessions. The company also provides free access to an Employee Assistance Program offering confidential counseling, available 24/7 via phone or video call.

A meal allowance of ■2,500 per month is credited via meal card for all employees working from a company office at least 3 days per week.

10. Learning and Development Policy

A learning and development allowance of ■40,000 per year is available for courses, certifications, and conference attendance directly relevant to the employee's role, subject to manager approval. Unused allowance does not carry forward to the following year.

Employees pursuing a certification directly aligned with their role (e.g. cloud provider certifications, PMP, relevant data or AI certifications) may claim 100% of exam fees in addition to the standard L&D; allowance, up to 2 certifications per year.

Internal mentorship programs pair every employee below L3 with a senior mentor for their first 12 months. Mentors are expected to meet with mentees at least twice per month.

Conference attendance requests exceeding ■75,000 in total cost (travel, accommodation, and registration combined) require Practice Director approval, regardless of whether the individual components fall within standard travel and expense caps.

11. Onboarding Process

New employees receive their laptop and system access credentials on Day 1. IT provisioning requests must be submitted by HR at least 3 business days before the employee's start date to ensure equipment is ready and configured.

First 90 Days

- **Week 1:** Company orientation, tool training, team introductions, and IT security onboarding module (mandatory, must be completed within 5 days).
- **Weeks 2–4:** Role-specific shadowing with a designated onboarding buddy, assigned for the first 30 days.
- **Day 30 check-in:** Structured conversation with the hiring manager covering early impressions, blockers, and goal-setting.
- **Day 60 check-in:** Progress review against initial goals; adjustments made if needed.
- **Day 90 check-in:** Formal confirmation of employment review, conducted jointly by the manager and HR.

The probation period is 90 days for all new hires. In rare cases, probation may be extended by up to 30 additional days if performance data is inconclusive, with written notice provided to the employee explaining the reason and specific expectations for the extension.

12. Performance Review and Promotion Policy

Formal performance reviews are conducted twice a year, in April and October. Each cycle includes a self-assessment, manager assessment, and peer feedback from at least 2 colleagues nominated by the employee and approved by the manager.

Ratings are given on a 5-point scale, where 3 represents 'meets expectations.' Employees rated 4 or above are eligible for the annual merit increase and bonus pool. Employees rated below 2 for two consecutive cycles are placed on a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) with a 60-day review window and clearly defined success criteria.

Promotion decisions are made once a year, following the October review cycle, and require endorsement from the employee's manager plus one skip-level approver. A promotion case must demonstrate sustained performance at the target level for at least 2 consecutive review cycles before nomination.

Employees who disagree with their rating may request a review through the Performance Review Appeals process within 10 working days of the rating being communicated, which is handled by HR independently of the original reviewing manager.

13. Health, Safety, and Workplace Policy

All office locations undergo a fire safety and evacuation drill twice a year. Attendance is mandatory for all employees present in the office on the scheduled drill day.

Ergonomic assessments are available on request through HR for any employee experiencing workplace discomfort, and the company will provide reasonable ergonomic equipment (chair, footrest, monitor arm) based on the assessment outcome at no cost to the employee.

Any workplace injury, regardless of severity, must be reported to HR and the office facilities team within 24 hours using the Incident Report form. Injuries resulting in more than 1 day of lost work trigger a mandatory review by the Health and Safety Committee.

Smoking is prohibited within all office premises, including balconies and building entrances. Designated smoking areas, where available, are located at least 15 meters from any building entrance in accordance with local regulations.

14. Grievance Redressal and Anti-Harassment Policy

Northwind Analytics maintains an Internal Complaints Committee (ICC) in compliance with applicable workplace harassment laws. Complaints may be filed confidentially through the ethics hotline, directly with the ICC, or through HR.

The ICC is required to complete its inquiry within 90 days of a complaint being filed. Interim measures, such as temporary reporting-line changes, may be implemented during the inquiry to protect the complainant, and retaliation against a complainant or witness is itself treated as a serious Code of Conduct violation.

Non-harassment grievances, including disputes over compensation, role scope, or manager conduct that do not involve harassment or discrimination, are handled through the standard Grievance Redressal process: a written complaint to HR, an investigation within 15 working days, and a documented resolution or escalation path.

15. Exit and Separation Policy

The standard notice period is 60 days for employees at L1–L4 and 90 days for employees at L5 and above. The company reserves the right to relieve an employee earlier than the notice period with payment in lieu of the remaining notice.

All company assets — laptop, access card, and any other issued equipment — must be returned on or before the last working day. Final settlement, including any pending reimbursements and encashable leave, is processed within 45 days of the last working day.

Exit interviews are conducted by HR for all departing employees and are optional but strongly encouraged. Feedback shared in an exit interview is kept confidential and is not shared with the departing employee's direct manager unless the employee explicitly consents.

Employees who resign and later wish to rejoin within 12 months are eligible for the Boomerang Rehire track, which waives the standard external-candidate interview loop and instead requires only a hiring manager conversation and updated reference check.

16. Employee Referral Bonus Policy

Referred Role Level	Bonus Amount	Payout Trigger
L1–L3	■25,000	Referred candidate completes 90 days
L4–L6	■50,000	Referred candidate completes 90 days
L7+ / niche skill roles	■1,00,000	Referred candidate completes 90 days

Referral bonuses are split 50/50 between the 90-day mark and the 180-day mark for roles at L4 and above, to encourage referrers to support the new hire's early success rather than treat the referral as a one-time transaction.

Employees in HR, Talent Acquisition, or with hiring authority over the specific role being filled are not eligible for a referral bonus on that role, to avoid conflicts of interest.

17. Data Retention and Privacy Policy

Client project data is retained for 5 years after project completion for audit and legal purposes, after which it is securely deleted unless a specific client contract requires a different retention period.

Employee personal data (HR records, performance reviews, payroll history) is retained for the duration of employment plus 7 years, in line with statutory record-keeping requirements, after which it is anonymized or deleted.

Employees have the right to request a copy of their personal data held by the company, or request correction of inaccurate data, by submitting a request to privacy@northwindanalytics.example. Requests are processed within 30 days.

18. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Can I take annual leave during my probation period?

A: Annual leave accrues from day 1 but cannot be taken until you complete 90 days of employment, except in genuine emergencies approved by your manager.

Q: Is overtime paid?

A: Northwind Analytics does not have a formal overtime pay structure, as the company's sustainable-pace value explicitly discourages routine overtime. Exceptional circumstances should be discussed with your manager on a case-by-case basis.

Q: Can I expense a client dinner that includes alcohol?

A: Yes, but alcohol is reimbursable only when entertaining external clients, capped at 50% of the total bill.

Q: What happens if I miss the 90-day window for the ICC inquiry?

A: The ICC is required to complete inquiries within 90 days; if this is exceeded, the matter is automatically escalated to the COO's office for review.

Q: Do referral bonuses apply to internal transfers?

A: No, referral bonuses only apply to external candidates who are new hires, not to internal transfers or rehires under the Boomerang Rehire track.

Q: Can I carry forward my learning and development allowance?

A: No, the ■40,000 annual L&D; allowance does not carry forward and resets each calendar year.